

Presenter: So, my very first question is, how do you prefer that I refer to your boyfriend? Do you prefer that I say your boyfriend, call him by his first name, your partner, your significant other? Do you have a preference?

Participant: I think I would prefer my boyfriend, I mean, for you to say my boyfriend.

Presenter: Okay, no problem. How long have you been together?

Participant: It's going to be [1-5] year and... [1-5] year and a half, a little less than [1-5] year and a half.

Presenter: Okay. Could you tell me about your love story? How did you meet, etc.?

Participant: So how did we meet? We met via [app]. So, it was my first [app] date, and we went out for a drink, and it was nice. And then we saw each other several times after that because we were both in the same city at that time, but I was going to leave in [1-5] weeks. So for [1-5] weeks, we saw each other very regularly. It was nice. And that's it, I don't know if I should elaborate more or if it's just about the meeting...

Presenter: Yes, how did your relationship develop? How did your feelings grow, etc.?

Participant: Okay. Well, for me, it happened pretty quickly, because when we talked by message, etc., I saw that we had some common points. I mean, yeah, common points, and that for me, they were very important values. For example, I know that everything related to feminist issues, etc., was okay. And then, yes, when we met, I realized that we got along very well, and since we saw each other very regularly, I know that for me, the feelings came pretty quickly. And actually, there was a bit of a pause because he went on [City] and I went to [City], so we were no longer in the same city or the same country. For [1-5] year, we stopped talking, and when he came back to [Country] and did an internship in [City], we talked again. Then we saw each other, and it was like the last time we saw each other. It was going very well, and it was nice. So, we decided that we wouldn't be a couple, but we would see each other regularly and be exclusive. And that's it. My feelings came back pretty quickly, and yes, I felt love pretty quickly too. We said "I love you" quite quickly, compared to other relationships I had before. And there was a period when it was a bit complicated because he had anxiety about commitment, about being in a couple. It wasn't a long period, but for a short while, and then it got better, and for a year now, it's been good. The relationship is more stable, that's what I wanted to say.

Presenter: Do you live together, I mean, do you live in the same place?

Participant: No, he's in [city], and I'm in [City], so since [Month], we've been in different regions. For a semester, we were in the same region because he was in [City], but that's it.

Presenter: So, you saw each other more often when he was closer?

Participant: Yes, that's right.

Presenter: And now, do you still see each other quite often, or is it complicated?

Participant: No, we still see each other quite often. At least once a month, in a month, a month and a half. And since I'm doing a master's in research, I had more time and could do things remotely. So often, I went to [city] because I had the time and stayed for a week, which was good. And since I had things to do in [city] like looking for an internship, there was an interest other than just seeing him that pushed me to go there. And from [Month], when I really needed to stay here to write my thesis, we saw each other a bit less frequently but for shorter times, just a weekend.

Presenter: Okay. If you had to compare your relationship with your boyfriend to the relationships your friends have, what would you say?

Participant: Yes, so it's going to sound very pretentious, but I feel like it's a healthy relationship. I have a few friends who have relationships that are quite healthy, but in general, I know that's one of the things I'm quite proud and happy about. I see that there's communication, I'm not afraid to say things. There's an expression of feelings, there's trust, and we both feel reassured. There's no ambiguity like I see in my friends' relationships, where they're in a couple but not really, where it's not very clear, or it's not very reciprocal, where everything is a bit more complicated. There's no guessing what the other person thinks, and I know that's not what I experience in this relationship. So, I'd say it's healthier than what I see around me.

Presenter: Okay, thank you. And now, if you compare your current relationship with your previous relationships, what would you say?

Participant: Okay, so before, I had [1-5] fairly long relationships. My very first relationship lasted about [6-10] months, and it wasn't great. The other one was a bit longer, about [1-5] years. I'd say, maybe it's logical, but this is the best relationship I've had so far. And how could I compare? Maybe because my first relationship was very bad, I see this one as very good. And I've tried to understand why my previous relationships didn't work and what I didn't want to find in a new partner. So, my last relationship before him was good, and I understood what worked and what didn't for me. So yeah, I'd say this is the best relationship I've had so far.

Presenter: And why was your first relationship so complicated?

Participant: Because we had personalities that didn't work well together, and it was my first relationship. I had this idea that there were rules to follow when you're in a couple, and there were things I wasn't comfortable with, but I felt like I had to do them anyway. I wasn't in control of the situation I was in. He was someone who got angry quickly and shut down, things like that. So, for these reasons, and because I didn't know how to act or where to place myself, I later understood that there were no rules and that I had to leave. Our personalities didn't match.

Presenter: Okay, thank you. Now, could you tell me what you think are the most important qualities in a relationship?

Participant: One quality... Or several?

Presenter: Yes, several.

Participant: Okay, well, first, trust, trusting each other. And along with that, communication, expressing how you feel, not just the difficult things or doubts but also the positive things. Saying to the person that they are beautiful, funny, things like that. It builds trust and makes you feel loved. So, for me, these are the two most important and complementary things. Another thing is having the same values, which forms a foundation and allows for more interesting and peaceful discussions. It also helps avoid fear of talking about certain topics. So, having the same values is very important to me, and I see that it's not always the case around me, but it's not a detail.

Presenter: And how do you know that your relationship is based on good communication, love, and trust? What shows you that in your daily life?

Participant: Well, expressing love, for example, for us, a lot is through writing since we see each other infrequently. But we also say it out loud, like saying you're beautiful, you're funny, I admire you, things like that. We express these things regularly, which is important. In terms of trust, I can talk about my doubts, not just related to the relationship but in general. For example, I'm quite anxious and stressed, and I've been able to share this part of myself without feeling

judged. It makes me feel loved for who I am, even the parts I don't like much. And he does the same, which builds trust and love.

Presenter: Okay. Is there a specific moment in your relationship when you felt the most communication, trust, and love?

Participant: Um... A specific moment... Maybe recently, when he adopted cats, and even though it was a well-thought-out decision, he felt anxious about it. He's usually not stressed, so the fact that he talked to me about his anxiety showed me that he trusted me not to judge him. It was about something important, and it made me feel that he was confident in sharing with me.

Presenter: Okay, thank you. On the other hand, is there a time when you felt your relationship lacked communication, trust, etc.?

Participant: Yes, as I briefly mentioned, there was a time when we decided to be a couple officially. He had anxiety about being the "perfect boyfriend," and for [1-5] weeks, he didn't talk about it. During that time, there was almost no communication about his anxiety, even though we talked. I thought everything was fine, but it wasn't, so that was a clear example.

Presenter: In general, what makes a relationship low-quality?

Participant: I think taking everything upon yourself and not talking about things that bother you because you're afraid to. This can lead to a buildup of negative feelings. Also, not having the same way of communicating can lead to misunderstandings and repeated arguments. Each person may shut down, and things are left unresolved. This can create a cycle of mediocre to bad moments without proper resolution.

Presenter: Now, I know you've already mentioned some things, but what do you think are the most important aspects of a romantic relationship?

Participant: Yes, so having the same values, having the same conception of what it means to be together, and being willing to express feelings, whether positive or negative. This builds trust and confidence.

Presenter: I see, thank you. Based on your experiences, what does love mean to you?

Participant: Yes, well, I've been thinking about this lately. Love is often highlighted in couples, but it's also important in friendships. It's a powerful feeling, making you feel strong because someone supports you. It's also a daily stability, knowing you're loved and supported. It helps you feel less alone, even if you don't always rely on that person.

Presenter: How do you know you're in love with your boyfriend?

Participant: I know I'm in love because I feel comfortable with him. I have a strong affection and desire for him, without any reservations. I don't have negative feelings or doubts about him, which gives me a sense of serenity and peace.

Presenter: Okay, I see, thank you. How important is love in a relationship to you?

Participant: I think it's central. I've always entered relationships with the potential of falling in love with the person. Love has always been a central part of my relationships, and I wouldn't stay with someone if I didn't feel it.

Presenter: How do you know your boyfriend loves you?

Participant: He tells me, and even when he doesn't say it directly, he shows it by being attentive, asking about my life, making me laugh, and doing things he knows I like. These actions show his love for me.

Presenter: Could you share a recent positive interaction with him?

Participant: A positive interaction... I think it was when I visited him [1-5] weeks ago in [city]. We had dinner at a new restaurant, which was nice. We talked and walked around the city. It was a sweet moment, and it was different from our usual routine.

Presenter: And a negative interaction?

Participant: A negative interaction... [Redacted]. He apologized afterward, but it hurt me at the moment.

Presenter: I understand. What challenges have you faced or are still facing in your relationship?

Participant: Communication is a challenge, especially since we're in a long-distance relationship. For example, [redacted].

Presenter: What are the recurring themes in your disputes?

Participant: We don't have many disputes, but small things like me being late or sensitive to his tone can cause minor conflicts. But we don't have recurring major disputes.

Presenter: How do you resolve these small disputes?

Participant: We talk about them. For example, when he cut the call short, I told him how it made me feel. For more significant disputes, we discuss them in-depth and revisit the topic to ensure we're both okay.

Presenter: Besides communication, what other ways do you maintain your relationship?

Participant: We make an effort to see each other regularly despite the distance. We talk daily and ask about each other's day. We call each other often and make plans to spend time together.

Presenter: Is there anything that could make you consider ending the relationship?

Participant: Yes, being cheated on or lied to. Also, a drastic change in values, like him suddenly supporting extreme right-wing views, or a significant increase in distance, like moving to the [Country], could be deal-breakers.

Presenter: Do you think this relationship is good for you?

Participant: Yes, it's good for me. It doesn't feel like a burden or work. It brings me joy and doesn't make me anxious, which is important given my previous bad relationship.

Presenter: Do you feel he helps you regulate your emotions?

Participant: Yes, because he's not anxious or stressed, unlike me. His calmness helps me see things differently and manage my stress better.

Presenter: Does he help you achieve your goals?

Participant: Not daily, but he supports me in bigger, more significant goals. For example, he encouraged me in my professional projects and helped me overcome my doubts.

Presenter: Do you feel like the same person as before your relationship?

Participant: Not really, but that's not just because of the relationship. I've grown in other areas too. I've learned to express myself better and confront things that bother me.

Presenter: Has your boyfriend changed since you've been together?

Participant: A little, in terms of dealing with his anxieties about being in a relationship. He's learned to manage his fears better. But overall, he hasn't changed much.

Presenter: How safe do you feel in this relationship?

Participant: Very safe. I don't have significant fears or doubts about his feelings or actions. There's a sense of stability and peace.

Presenter: What makes you feel safe? Any specific examples?

Participant: Feeling loved, being able to talk about anything, knowing he's there for me, and not worrying about his actions when he's out with friends or doesn't respond for a while.

Presenter: Does he provide you with the comfort and attention you need when you're feeling down?

Participant: Yes, even though the distance makes it a bit challenging. He supports me a lot, especially during stressful times, like when I was writing my thesis.

Presenter: How important is the sexual aspect of your relationship to you?

Participant: It's important but not the most important. It's part of the desire and love I feel for him.

Presenter: What's the frequency of your sexual relations when you spend a week together?

Participant: About two or three times a week.

Presenter: Are you satisfied with your current sex life?

Participant: Yes and no. I enjoy it, but I think I could enjoy it more if we had more time together.

Presenter: What could improve your sexual relationship?

Participant: More time together and less fatigue. Being able to discover each other more in that aspect.

Presenter: I'm going to share my screen to show you some scales between 1 and 9.

Participant: Okay.

Presenter: How much do you agree with "My partner really listens to me" between 1 and 9?

Participant: I'd say 9.

Presenter: Why 9?

Participant: Because when I talk, he takes the time to listen, even if he doesn't always respond as much as I'd like. He doesn't take what I say lightly.

Presenter: Can you give specific examples?

Participant: Recently, I talked about being nervous about joining a new team, and he shared similar experiences to show he understood.

Presenter: How much do you agree with "My partner is generally attentive to my needs" between 1 and 9?

Participant: I'd say 8 because there are times when he reassures me about stressful situations and encourages me, especially during my thesis writing.

Presenter: How satisfied are you with your relationship on a scale of 0 to 10?

Participant: I'd say 8.

Presenter: Why 8 and not 7 or 9?

Participant: Not 7 because it's not just average; it brings me joy and I don't have doubts. But not 9 or 10 because sometimes I wish he was more curious or engaged in conversations about my life.

Presenter: Is there anything else you'd like to add?

Participant: No, I think that's it.